



Anxiety in Tech

Dennie Declercq // 2023





Intro

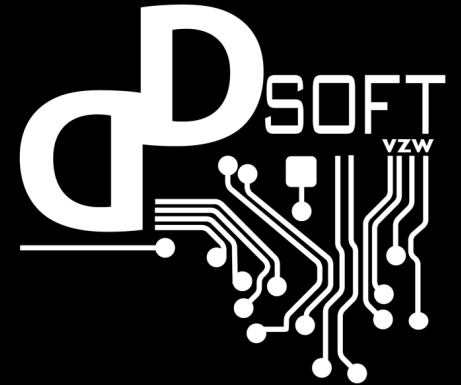
Content

- Intro
- Introduction to Anxiety
- Anxiety in Tech Tasks
- Anxiety in Tech Roles
- Indirect Anxiety in Tech
- How to cope anxiety
- Outro



Who am I?

- Dennie Declercq
- President & IT-coach DDSoft
- Microsoft MVP
- @DennieDeclercq
- **Mr. DreamingIsBelieving**

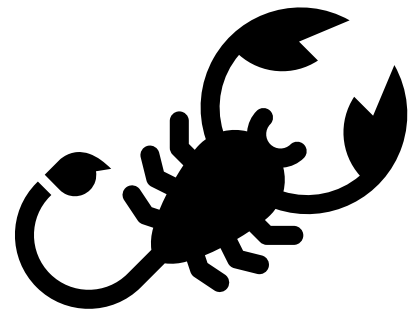


Travel lover
People lover
Modern Eastern Spirituality

How my history impacts my anxiety today

- As child I was bullied a lot.
- Big traumatic experience when I was 13yo (Child Psychiatry).
- The teachers didn't believe my programmers knowledge & abilities.
- My parents are not in tech.
- Recognition, Acceptance, Permission, Allowance always fighting points.





Introduction to Anxiety

Positive (High)	Joy		Amazement	
Negative (Low)	Anxiety	Rage	Grief	Aversion

What is Anxiety

- Prime Emotion
- Ancient Surviving **instinct** in danger
- Negative (Low Energy)

Types of Anxiety



Separation anxiety



Fear of rejection



Fear of failure

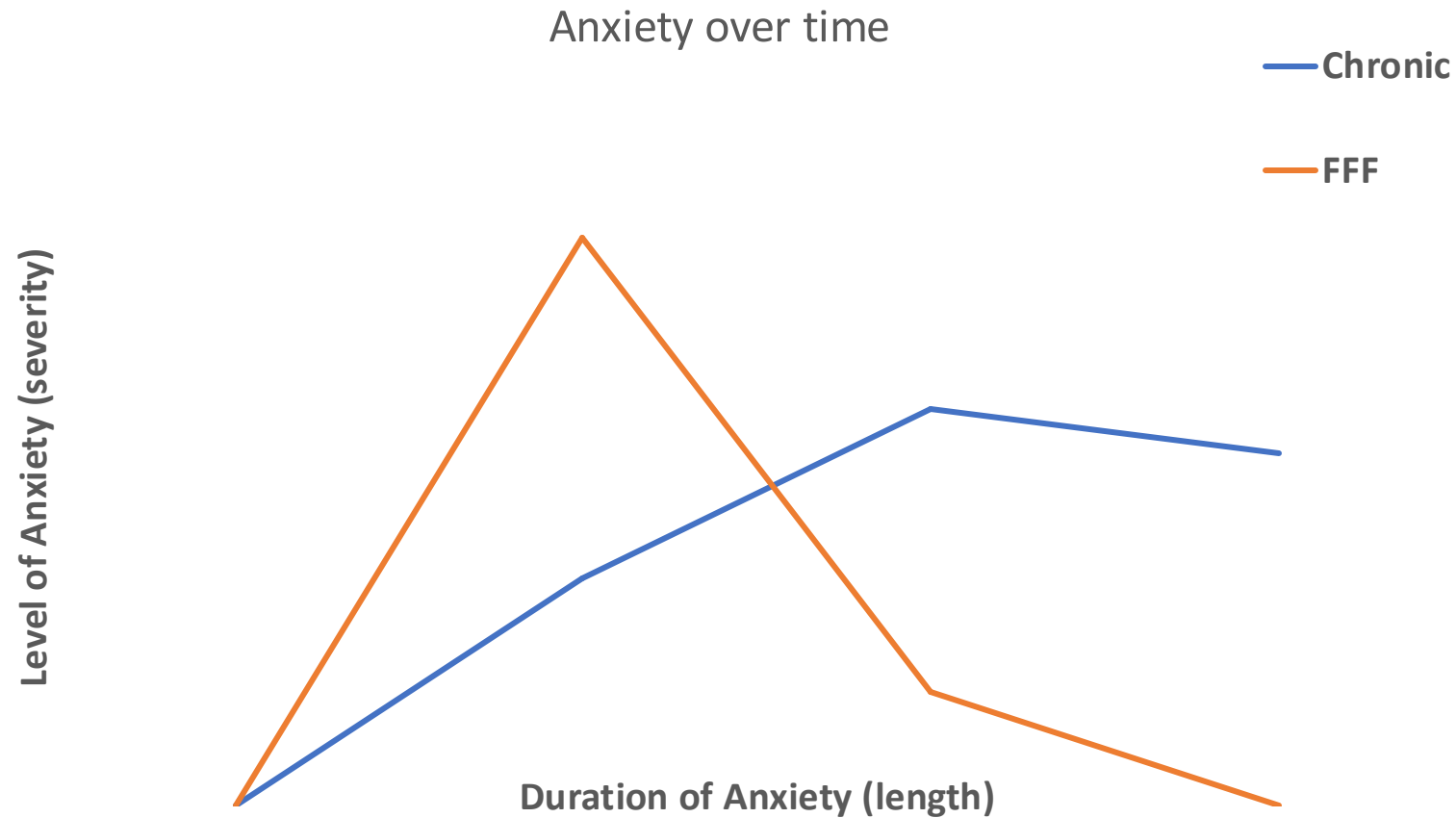


Fear of accusation



Fear of dying

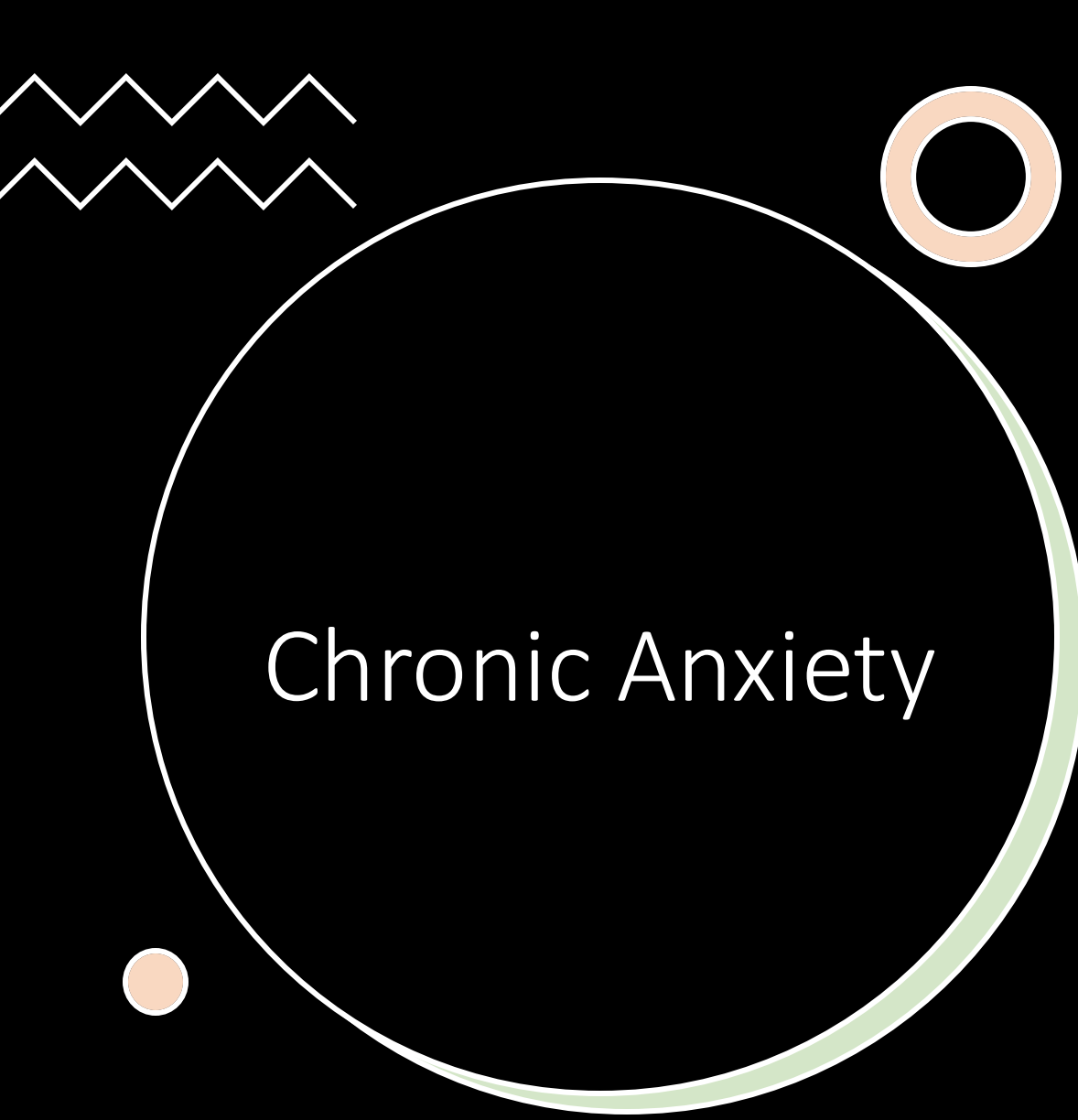
Duration of Anxiety





Fight, Flight, Freeze

- Basic instinct (Ancient animals)
- Real Fears
 - Car Crash
 - System Failure
 - Risk of bad choice
 - Risk of disastrous consequences
 - Unexpected bad customer call
- Panic



Chronic Anxiety

Long term

Long periods
of discomfort

Bad sleep/
Insomnia

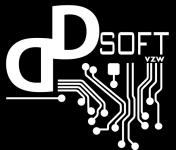
Mulling/
fretting

Hyper alert

Physical
tension

Your Mental Back-pack

- Direct impact on:
 - Feelings
 - Thoughts
 - Experiences
 - Circumstances happening right now
 - Brain wires
 - Physical body structure/ Muscles



Good vs Bad Anxiety

Good

- Can save you!
- Is short!

Bad

- All the rest

Anxiety in Tech Tasks

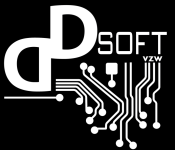


It works, Keep it (the legacy way)!

- It works, it's not perfect
- A rebuild can trigger new problems
- Low self-esteem causes anxiety
- What if a customer need it when it's broken?
- What if I can't fix it?

Bad Git Branches

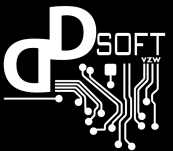
- A lack of Git usage is a major trigger
- Good Git knowledge definitely helps
- A solid branching strategy provide enough backups
- A roll-back strategy leads to safety



DennieDeclercq

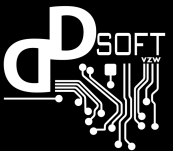
Unclear Package documentation

- Let's talk Maven, Gradle, NuGet, NPM
- What about package minor updates?
- What about package major updates?
- Are breaking changes announced?
- When is a version deprecated?
- Major changes & learning a complete new package is hell.



Unannounced breaking changes

- Breaking changes are not only in packages!
- Software (IDE's, Editors).
- Languages (Java, C, C#) versions.
- Frameworks (Angular, React, Node, .NET).



Announced
breaking
changes but
deadlines &
workload issues

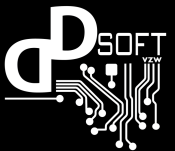
Announced breaking change
with:

- Short due date
- A lot of work to do

In combination with:

- A lot of customer work
- Small team

Then, it can trigger loads of
Anxiety!



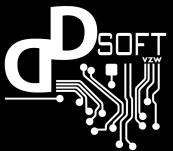
Alfa, Beta, Prod

You are using a Beta version from a 3rd party for your production...?

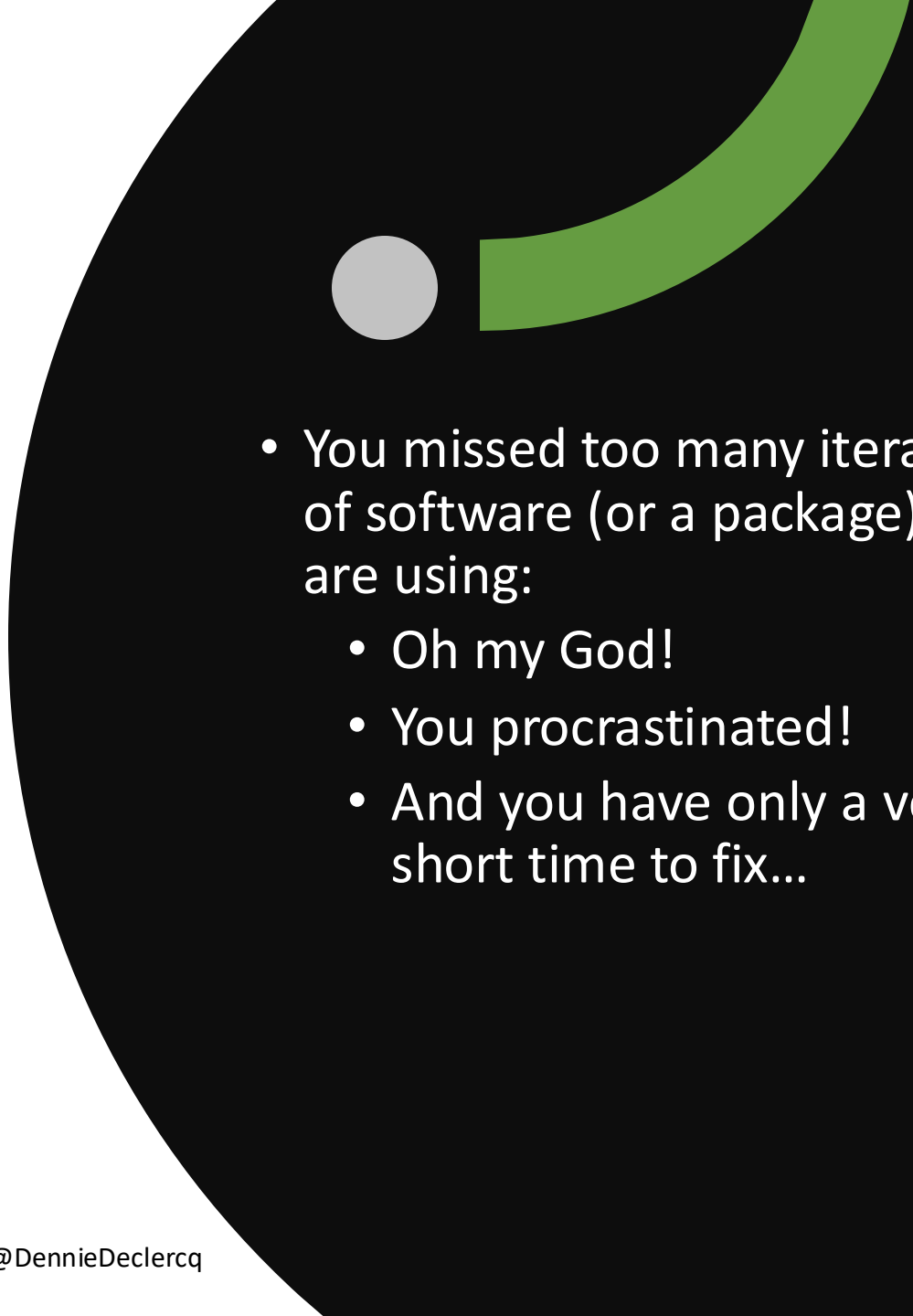
- You know you shouldn't.
- At first you saw only benefits.

And now your production is broken?

- Are you scared for guilt feeling?
- How do you communicate with your customers?
- And/ or 3rd Party?

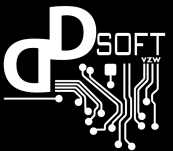


Left
behind if
too slow
to pivot

- 
- You missed too many iterations of software (or a package) you are using:
 - Oh my God!
 - You procrastinated!
 - And you have only a very short time to fix...

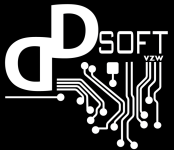
Cloud Architecture

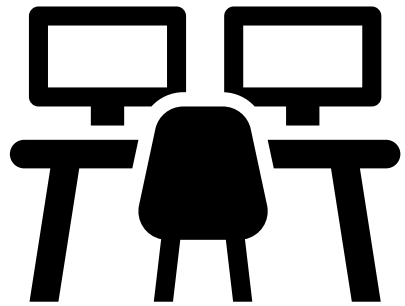
- Your cloud Application works. It works, but it's too slow.
- You have paid customers/ users. Some complain. Some are OK (price).
- And there's a new Cloud Architecture that will solve your needs!
- Are you?
 - Scared to move and left the old project behind?
 - Brave enough to build it in a short timespan? Is it possible?
 - Do you mail your customers for an announced service stop (During Holidays)?
 - Just keep working the legacy way? With its trade-offs?



Security and Blaming

- Does security feels like safety? Of like danger?
- Is making your apps/systems secure stressfull?
- Will you get blamed even for good intent?
- Is good intent enough?
- Of do you put your dream project in a wintersleep?
 - Just for your security/ safety?





Anxiety in Tech Roles



There's no Single Point of Contact



- For your customer you need:
 - 3rd Party hosting;
 - Personal contact is difficult, they are hard to reach.
- But your customer don't understand:
 - What 's your part;
 - What's the 3rd Party's part?
- How do you cope this?
- Are you frustrated?
- Are you anxious to lose your customer/money?



Customer Expectations

- Customer needs feature;
 - Customer 'need' it urgent;
 - You know you don't have capacity;
 - Are you promising for over-delivery?
 - Will you be anxious if you fail?
 - Is failure an option?
- Or are you saying: "It isn't possible"?
 - Is customer King?
 - Can a King do everything?
 - Will the customer leave? Anxious?

Say: NO!

- Dare to say NO!
- X is not possible in x amount of time!
- X is not possible with only x amount of people!
- X is too much!
- I need to charge X or need X to make an exception!
 - BUT be aware if people step by for your requirements;
 - Will this make the solution realistic?
 - Or cause additional anxiety?
 - Know what YOU WANT/NEED

Anxious for Scarcity



- You are asking too little money.
 - You are overdelivering.
 - You are sacrificing family life.
 - You are stressed if you look your bank account.
-
- Are you scared for running low?
 - Is this realistic or only a falsehood feeling?



stackoverflow

They don't
believe in me!

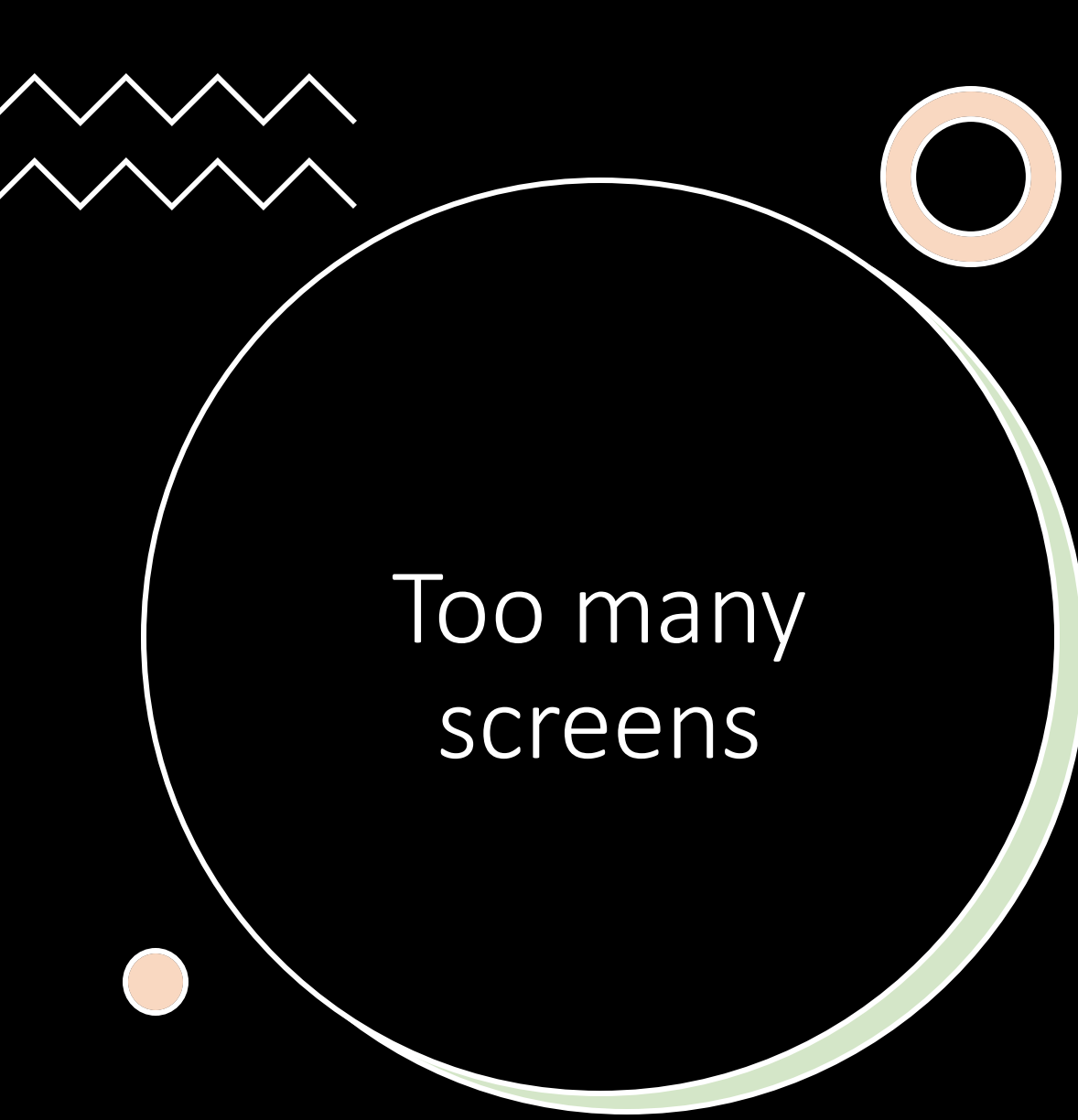
- If I ask a 'stupid' question on Stack Overflow...
- If I don't know each datatype of the language that I use, even the lesser known ones...
- If I don't find the right terminology to Google it...
- If I make a typo in a GitHub repo...
- G*D D*mn I will mess up another's GitHub Repo...
- If I raise my hand to ask a stupid question at a session at this conference...

I am not professional!

- If I don't know everything...
- If I ask a beginner questions...
- If all my sessions I choose are beginner sessions (Level 100)...
- If I don't have a current job/ employer...



Indirect Anxiety in Tech



Too many screens

- At your work; Or a virtual conference:
 - Multiple monitors (2+, 3+)
 - Your dev work takes 1 or 2
- What about the other?
- Power off?
- Let it on?
- Sneaky following the news?
- Doomscrolling on Social Media?

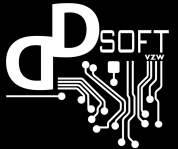
Virtual blah, blah & Newspapers



Social Media



- Doomscrolling all day?
- Are you frustrated for bad reactions?
 - On your company or personal choices?
 - Do you need to react?
- Are people toxic?
- Are you sometimes toxic?
- Can you unplug?
- Can you only follow the positive stuff?





How to Cope Anxiety?

Take a break



THE ANSWER
CAN COME OUT
OF THE BOX



THE PROBLEM
CAN LOOK
LESS SEVERE
AS YOU
THOUGHT



REPLACE FOCUS
AWAY FROM
THE PROBLEM



TAKE A WALK



BELIEVE IN THE
POWER OF
BEING
UNPRODUCTIVE

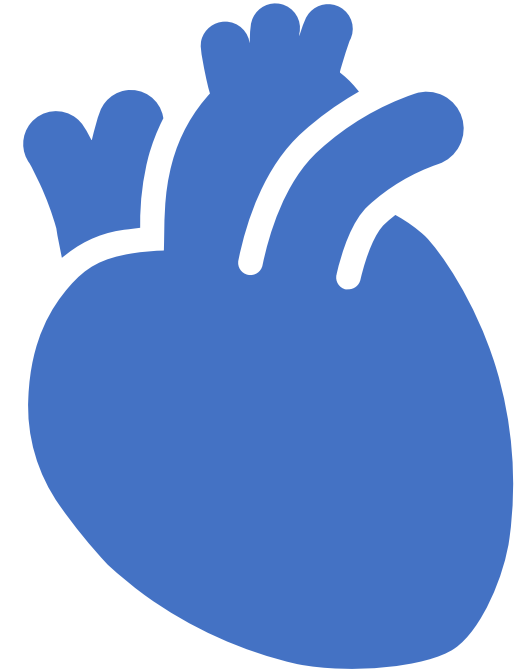


COMMUNICATION!!!

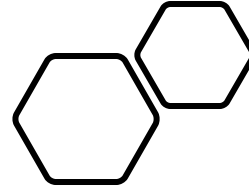
- Open & Honest
- Trust the good ones
- Be vulnerable
- Indicate your limits & borders
- You are not alone

Breathing Exercises

- Based on Heart-Brain-Coherence
- Apps
- Physiotherapist
- Some formulas:
 - 4'-4'-4'-4'
 - 4'-7'-8'-0'



Medical help



- My GP is needed
 - Trust in GP is key
 - The patient has rights!
 - You CAN say: I don't want...
 - Medication is no taboo
-
- "Your brain is part of your body, medication can heal the body"





Outro



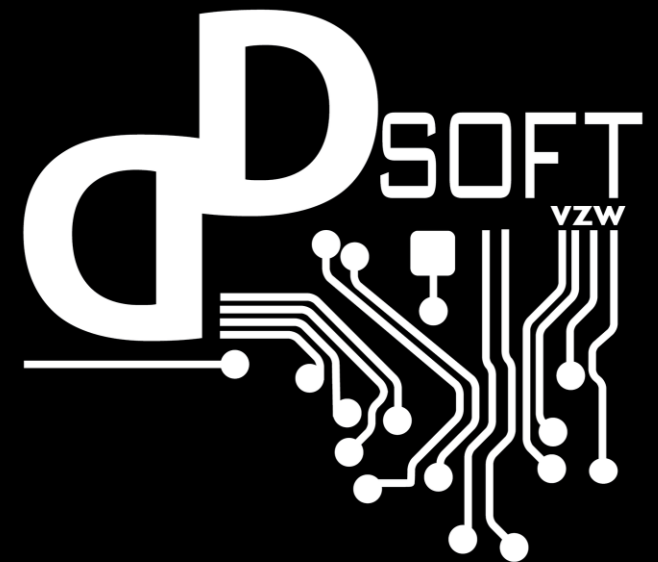
Recap

- I explained the emotion Anxiety
- I told about Anxiety in Tech Tasks
 - You can ask help!
- I told about Anxiety in Tech Roles
 - You need to follow your limit & borders!
- I told about Indirect Anxiety in Tech
 - Less is more!
- I gave tips to handle anxiety
 - COMMUNICATION = KEY!



Thanks // Q&A

- @DennieDeclercq
- #DreamingIsBelieving
- dennie@ddsoft.be



@DennieDeclercq